

DDL 7007 - Design Probes

The Probe: "The Residue Application & The Viewfinder"

1. The Minimal Physical Component: The "Isolation Viewfinder."

- **What it is:** A simple business-card-sized piece of black cardstock with a square cut out of the center.
- Just cut a rectangle out of a thick piece of paper.
- **Its purpose:** When someone feels overwhelmed by the crowd, holding up this physical frame forces them to isolate a single visual element (a pair of shoes, a blurry face, a ticket gate). It acts as a physical "anchor" to ground them.

2. The App Component:

- **What it is:** A minimalist camera app.
- **The Interaction:** The user holds up their physical "Viewfinder," opens the app, and takes a photo *through* the hole in the card. The app automatically applies a heavy blur/distortion filter to the image (ensuring privacy of strangers) and asks them to attach a single "Signal" (e.g., "Invisible," "Suffocating," "Drifting"). The app then anonymously drops this image onto a shared digital map of the metro system.
- **Frequency:** Strictly "Trigger-Based." There is no quota. Users are instructed to use the probe only when they feel a sudden spike in the feeling of being "alone in a crowd."
- **Action Initiated:** The moment the user swipes their transit card at the entry gate.
- **Action Ended:** The moment they swipe out and exit into the open air. The probe is strictly for the subterranean/transit realm.

3. Literature:

1. The Concept of "Non-Places" (Marc Augé)

The Theory: In *Non-Places: Introduction to an Anthropology of Supermodernity*, Augé defines "non-places" as spaces of transience—such as airports, motorways, and metro stations. Unlike "anthropological places," which are historical, relational, and concerned with identity, non-places strip individuals of their unique identities. In a metro, you are no longer a student, a designer, or a friend; you are simply a "passenger" following instructions (swipe here, stand here). This shared anonymity creates a profound sense of solitude, even when surrounded by thousands of people.

This probe specifically targets this "solitude of similitude." The metro is designed to prevent lingering or emotional connections. By asking users to leave an emotional "Signal" pinned to a specific spot on a

digital transit map, my probe acts as an act of quiet rebellion. It attempts to temporarily convert a "non-place" into an "anthropological place" by attaching a subjective human emotion to an otherwise sterile environment.

2. The Methodology of "Cultural Probes" (Gaver, Dunne, & Pacenti)

The Theory: The original *Cultural Probes* paper establishes that probes are not meant to collect objective, statistical, or comprehensive data (which is what traditional surveys and interviews do). Instead, they are designed to be provocative, ambiguous, and aesthetic. They are meant to elicit "inspirational responses" and uncover the subjective, emotional textures of people's daily lives. Gaver specifically used tools like disposable cameras with strange prompts (e.g., "Photograph the spiritual center of my home").

How it validates my Probe: This is my strongest defense against the question, "*Why not just use an interview?*" * **Provocation over precision:** The physical "Isolation Viewfinder" is intentionally strange. Holding up a piece of black cardstock with a hole in it disrupts the user's normal routine.

- **Ambiguity:** Asking users to capture a heavily blurred, distorted image of a stranger's shoes or a ticket gate doesn't give you objective data about metro capacity. It gives you the *mood* and *texture* of their isolation. Interviews demand logic; my probe captures raw feeling.

3. Separation and Connection (e.g., The Bridge and the Door)

The Theory: Sociological theories of space (often traced back to Georg Simmel's *Bridge and Door*) discuss the human necessity to both separate and connect. A "door" represents our ability to isolate ourselves and create boundaries, while a "bridge" represents our active will to connect things that are separated.

How it validates my Probe: my hybrid physical/digital probe perfectly embodies this dichotomy:

- **The Door (Separation):** The physical Isolation Viewfinder. When a user feels overwhelmed by the crowd, the physical frame acts as a "door," helping them isolate a tiny fragment of their vision and block out the overwhelming whole.
- **The Bridge (Connection):** The App. By anonymously uploading that isolated feeling to a shared digital map, the app acts as a "bridge," connecting their private moment of loneliness to the broader, invisible community of commuters experiencing the exact same thing.

3. Research Questions:

- **Primary RQ:** How can an asynchronous design intervention disrupt the anonymity of "non-places" (Augé) to alleviate commuter isolation?
- **Secondary RQ:** How does framing the physical environment through a restrictive lens alter a commuter's perception of feeling "alone in a crowd"?